AN ORIGINAL COUNTRY-HOUSE MYSTERY

THE LAST BELL OF ASHCOMBE HOUSE

CHARACTER CARDS

Six illustrated suspect dossiers. All cards are shared information; no participant plays the murderer.



1-6 INVESTIGATORS | 90-120 MINUTES | AGES 14+

An autumn storm. Six suspects. One unfinished announcement.

SUSPECT 01 / ARCHIVIST, 36

Celia Ward



APPEARANCE

Plum jacket; pale violet cuffs; round spectacles.

POSSIBLE PRESSURE

Edmund questioned her records and asked her to bring the blue folio.

CLAIMED MOVEMENTS

Borrowed the cupboard key at 9:10. Says she left the library in under a minute and stayed in the archive until 9:20. No witness confirms the intervening minutes.

SECRET OR DISPUTED CLAIM

Says the right cuff tore that afternoon. Says the missing drawing is in York for conservation.

Evidence links: Compare E03, E05, E06, E07 and E08.

Question for investigators: Which claims have independent support? What does the photograph actually disprove?

Portrait is atmospheric artwork. Solve from the written observations and labeled evidence, not from facial expression or clothing details in the illustration.

SUSPECT 02 / NIECE, 27

Nora Ashcombe



APPEARANCE

Emerald evening dress; pearl earrings.

POSSIBLE PRESSURE

Owes money after supporting a theatre company. Feared losing the house and her allowance.

CLAIMED MOVEMENTS

Martha places her upstairs from 9:12 to 9:18, holding a lamp while the leak was inspected.

SECRET OR DISPUTED CLAIM

Concealed a creditor letter in her evening bag. She later surrendered it.

Evidence links: Compare E02, E04 and E10.

Question for investigators: Does a financial motive outweigh a corroborated account of her location?

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SUSPECT 03 / FAMILY DOCTOR, 49

Dr Felix Mercer



APPEARANCE

Charcoal suit; white shirt; neat moustache.

POSSIBLE PRESSURE

Edmund threatened to withdraw support from a clinic Felix had endorsed.

CLAIMED MOVEMENTS

Call connected at 9:09. Gideon saw him in the alcove at 9:13 and 9:16. The interval is not continuously witnessed.

SECRET OR DISPUTED CLAIM

Initially resisted questions about his professional dispute.

Evidence links: Compare E02 and E04.

Question for investigators: Which minutes are observed, and which are assumptions?

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SUSPECT 04 / ART AND MANUSCRIPT DEALER, 44

Gideon Pike



APPEARANCE

Tan suit; burgundy tie; blond hair.

POSSIBLE PRESSURE

Bought works under letters of authority supplied by Celia; exposure could damage his business.

CLAIMED MOVEMENTS

Investigator places him at the map-room doorway when the bell sounded at 9:14.

SECRET OR DISPUTED CLAIM

Accepted a restoration-fund explanation without asking Edmund directly.

Evidence links: Compare E04 and E06.

Question for investigators: Does the machine defect identify an author, or only a machine?

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SUSPECT 05 / HOUSEKEEPER, 57

Martha Reed



APPEARANCE

Navy dress; white collar; pinned grey-streaked hair.

POSSIBLE PRESSURE

Worried about staff and Nora. Edmund had privately promised continued employment under the trust.

CLAIMED MOVEMENTS

With Nora upstairs from 9:12 to 9:18. Delivered the bell at 9:08. Saw the key returned at 9:22.

SECRET OR DISPUTED CLAIM

First omitted the upstairs trip to protect Nora from embarrassment, then corrected her account.

Evidence links: Compare E03, E04 and E10.

Question for investigators: Does an omission explain another secret rather than the killing?

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SUSPECT 06 / GROUNDSKEEPER, 41

Arthur Bell



APPEARANCE

Brown work coat; muddy boots; borrowed tie.

POSSIBLE PRESSURE

Had taken estate coal for his sister and feared dismissal.

CLAIMED MOVEMENTS

Heard the bell and the service door at 9:14 from a bend in the corridor. Reached the kitchen about 9:17.

SECRET OR DISPUTED CLAIM

Admitted taking coal. Never claimed to have seen the person at the service door.

Evidence links: Compare E04 and E12.

Question for investigators: What can a sound establish? Why is an ordinary muddy mark not a unique identification?

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CUT APART IF USEFUL

Investigator reference cards

OBSERVATION

What did someone directly see, hear or record? Include source and time.

CLAIM

Whose account is this? Has anyone independently corroborated it?

CONTRADICTION

Name two statements that cannot both be correct. Do not silently choose one.

ACCUSATION

Combine motive, opportunity and physical connection. Address your strongest alternative suspect.